Letter of Support for Professor Mohammad Dehghani

INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice

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INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice Committee

Dear Members of the Committee,

I am writing in support of Professor Mohammad Dehghani's nomination for the 2026 INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice. I am a Ph.D. candidate in Mechanical and Industrial Engineering at Northeastern University, and I took Professor Dehghani's IE 5374, Applied Generative AI. The course gave me a practical understanding of large language models and how they can be used in applied technical workflows.

The course covered LLM capabilities, limitations, prompting strategies, agentic workflows, evaluation, and deployment. These topics were taught through projects, labs, and class discussions, which made the material usable beyond the classroom. For my own work, the course helped me think less about using an LLM as a standalone tool and more about designing a workflow around it.

After taking IE 5374, I participated in HackPrinceton 2026S and won first place in the Knot Track. The course helped me contribute to the system architecture, reasoning workflow, and evaluation process. I was also nominated by MBZUAI's Institute of Foundation Models, the group behind K2, which was connected to the same line of applied LLM work.

Professor Dehghani also gave me the opportunity to present at Google and receive feedback from industry practitioners. That experience connected the course material with professional expectations around generative AI systems, product thinking, and technical communication. As a Ph.D. student, I found this useful because it placed technical ideas in a broader applied context.

The curriculum reflected current developments in LLMs, agentic systems, development tools, and applied AI workflows. The course was practical and current, while still requiring students to reason about system design, limitations, and evaluation. I expect this framework to remain useful in my research and future AI-related work.

For these reasons, I support Professor Dehghani's nomination for the INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice.

Sincerely,

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HackPrinceton 2026S, first place in the Knot Track.